13 – Guardrails

Definition: Guardrails are rules and filters that control what an AI accepts, outputs, and does – set by the provider or by you yourself.

> **Remember:** Filters block a lot, but not everything. The last guardrail is you.

Key points

- **Four layers:**
  1. **Provider filters** (built into the AI, not under your control)
  2. **Instructions** (system prompt, project instructions, your own rules in the chat)
  3. **Technical checks** (format checks, tools with limited permissions)
  4. **Human approval** (you review and confirm before something happens)
- **Limits:** Filters can be bypassed (see prompt injection, topic 12), are error-prone, and are sometimes too strict – then they block harmless requests.
- **Your own guardrails:** phrase clear instructions, e.g. “Do not give legal or tax advice” or “If information is missing, ask instead of making it up”.
- **Format checks:** requirements like “table only, no extra text” make results easier to check.
- **Second opinion:** have important results reviewed by a second AI or a subject-matter expert.
- **Trying jailbreaks is risky:** trick attempts can violate the terms of service and lead to account suspension – and they get you nowhere.

Example

Your own guardrails for an assistant that writes drafts for you:

```
Rules for our collaboration:
1. Don't invent facts, names, or numbers. If something is missing,
↪  ask.
2. Don't give legal or medical advice; point me to professionals
↪  instead.
3. Mark placeholders clearly: [NAME], [DATE].
4. End every draft with a list of the uncertain points.
```

These rules don’t replace a review, but they catch many typical mistakes before you pass the result on.

Do / Don’t

Do	Don’t
Phrase your own rules clearly and positively	Leave rule requests vague (“Be responsible”)
Review results yourself before passing them on	Click away provider filter warnings without reading them
Treat results from the chat as a draft	Publish AI output unchecked

Safety note

Attempts to bypass safety filters (jailbreaks) can violate the terms of service and lead to account suspension. If the AI declines something you need, turn to a professional or to support instead of trying to work around the filters.

Mini checklist

- ☐ I know the four layers of guardrails.
- ☐ I have phrased my own rules for tasks I use frequently.
- ☐ I treat AI answers as a draft, not a finished product.
- ☐ I know: filters can be bypassed – the last check is me.

Exercise (5 min.)

Phrase five of your own rules for an assistant that helps you daily (emails, texts, planning). Write them in a note file and test them in your next chat: does the AI stick to them? Where it doesn't, sharpen the rule.

Next steps

- Extra exercises: `02_extra_exercises/13_extra_exercises`
- Test: Test C (Risks)
- Related: 12 prompt injection, 21 agent safety, 05 prompt basics

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